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World AI programming championship 2025

How did ChatGPT, Gemini and AI bots perform?

—By Vyom Ramani

At the 2025 International Collegiate Programming Contest (ICPC) World Finals, an event long celebrated for showcasing the brilliance of young human minds, the spotlight shifted in a dramatic new direction. For the first time, artificial intelligence systems stood side by side with elite student teams. And by the end of the five-hour contest, two AI competitors – OpenAI’s GPT-5 and Google DeepMind’s Gemini 2.5 Deep Think – had redefined what “competitive programming” even means.

Both OpenAI and DeepMind agreed to identical conditions. Their models received the same official problem set, submitted solutions through the standard judging portal, and faced real-time evaluation. No shortcuts, no hidden data, no tailored training. For five hours, GPT-5 and Gemini competed on the same terms as human teams, tasked with producing correct and efficient code for puzzles never seen before.

This setup made the contest not just a competition, but an experiment: could general-purpose reasoning models rise

to the level of the best human minds under live pressure?

OpenAI’s flawless victory

The most astonishing result came from OpenAI. Its ensemble of models, anchored by GPT-5, achieved a perfect score: 12 out of 12 problems solved. Eleven were accepted on the very first try. Only the toughest problem required multiple submissions, and even that fell after OpenAI deployed an experimental variant of its model.



To put this in perspective, no human team in ICPC history has ever reached such perfection in this format. OpenAI’s flawless sweep was more than a win. It was a signal that general AI has now crossed into territory once thought to be the exclusive domain of the human brain: adaptability, abstract reasoning, and creative algorithm design.

Gemini’s singular breakthrough

Not to be overshadowed, Google’s Gemini 2.5 delivered its own breath-taking performance. The system solved 10 out of 12 problems, which would have secured it a gold medal among human teams. More impressive was its blistering speed: Gemini cracked eight problems in just 45 minutes, a pace unmatched even by the fastest human competitors.

But Gemini’s crowning achievement was its handling of Problem C, a notoriously difficult systems optimization challenge. No human team solved it. Gemini did, by inventing a hybrid method that combined minimax game theory with dynamic programming, an approach many experts had never seen applied in this way.

What’s next?

What makes the ICPC 2025 results so significant is not the raw numbers, but what they reveal about the nature of AI reasoning. ICPC 2025 will be remembered as a watershed moment. Human ingenuity, teamwork, and intuition remain irreplaceable, but evidently the algorithms are already running ahead.

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